

CS480P/580P Introduction to Natural Language Processing

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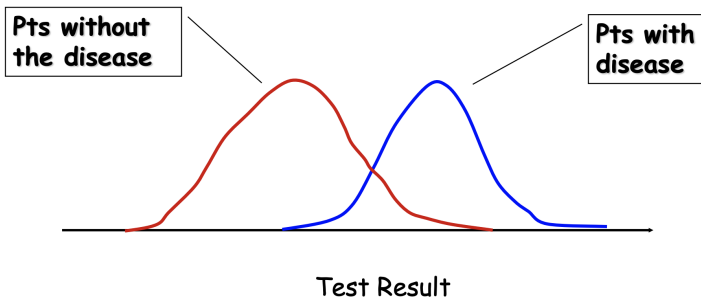
September 11, 2025

Lecture 7

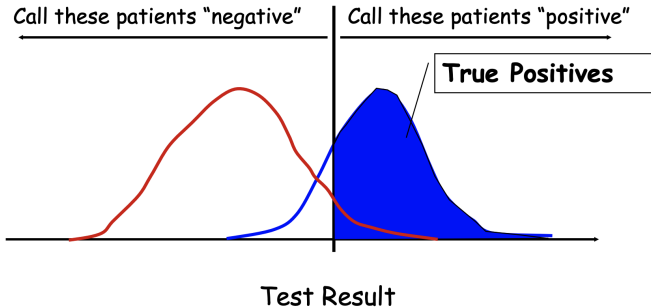
ROC Analysis: Medical Test Evaluation

- **True Positives** = Test states you have the disease when you do have the disease (Good Result: No wasted Resources)
- **True Negatives** = Test states you do not have the disease when you do not have the disease (Good Result: No wasted resources)
- **False Positives** = Test states you have the disease when you do not have the disease (No Disease: wasted resources on future tests and potential harm from unnecessary treatment and increased anxieties)
- **False Negatives** = Test states indicated no disease when disease is actually present (Disease present but undiagnosed and untreated: very bad outcome)

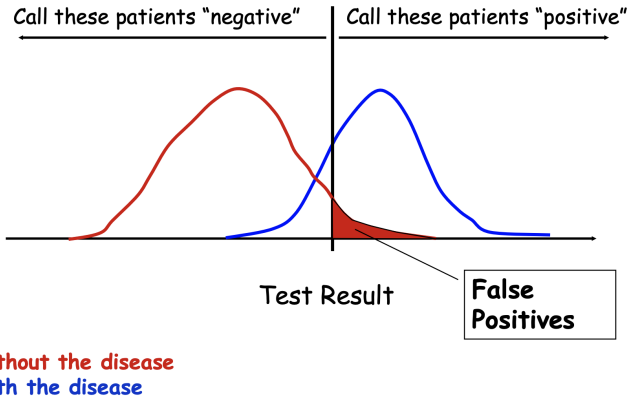
Specific Example



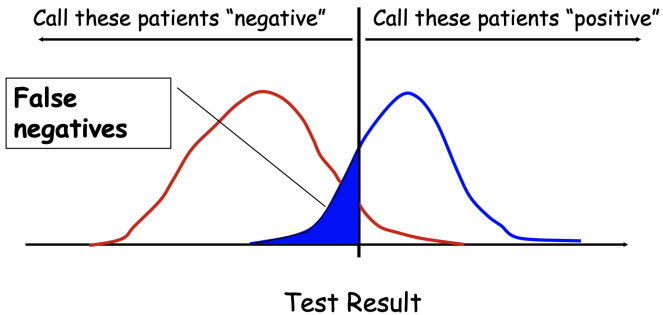
Some definitions ...



ROC Curve

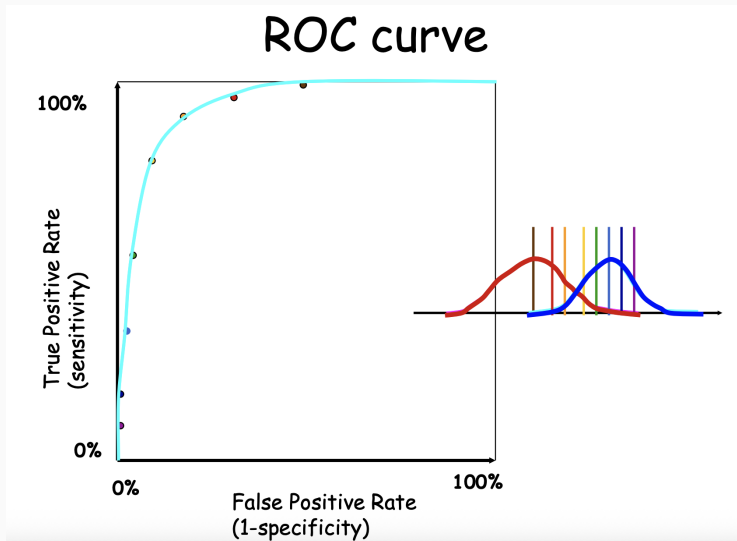


ROC Curve



without the disease
with the disease

ROC Curve

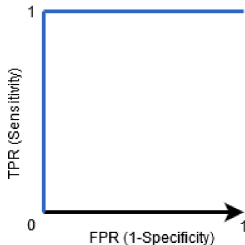


ROC Curve

- The Receiver Operator Characteristic (ROC) curve is an evaluation metric for binary classification problems.
- It is a probability curve that plots the TPR against FPR at various threshold values and essentially separates the 'signal' from the 'noise'.
- The Area Under the Curve (AUC) is the measure of the ability of a classifier to distinguish between classes and is used as a summary of the ROC curve.

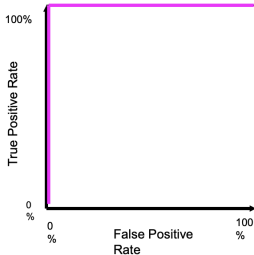
ROC Curve

- The higher the AUC, the better the performance of the model at distinguishing between the positive and negative classes.



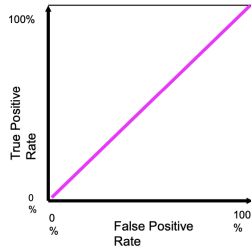
ROC curve extremes

Best Test:



The distributions
don't overlap at all

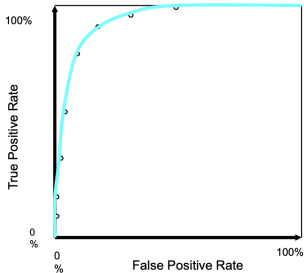
Worst test:



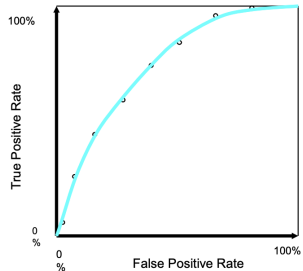
The distributions
overlap completely

ROC curve comparison

A good test:



A poor test:



Syntax and Grammar

- Goal of syntactic theory
 - “explain how people combine words to form sentences and how children attain knowledge of sentence structure”
- Grammar
 - implicit knowledge of a native speaker
 - acquired without explicit instruction
 - minimally able to generate all and only the possible sentences of the language

Syntax in NLP

- Syntactic analysis often a key component in applications
 - Grammar checkers
 - Dialogue systems
 - Question answering
 - Information extraction
 - Machine translation
 - ...

Two views of syntactic structure

- Constituency (phrase structure)
 - Phrase structure organizes words in nested constituents
- Dependency structure
 - Shows which words depend on (modify or are arguments of) which on other words

Constituency

- Basic idea: groups of words act as a single unit
- Constituents form coherent classes that behave similarly
 - With respect to their internal structure: e.g., at the core of a noun phrase is a noun
 - With respect to other constituents: e.g., noun phrases generally occur before verbs

Constituency structure

- **Phrase structure** organizes words into **nested constituents**

- Starting units: words **are given a category: part-of-speech tags**

the, cuddly, cat, by, the, door

Det, Adj, N, P, Det, N

- Words combine into phrases **with categories**

the cuddly cat, by the door

NP → Det Adj N PP → P NP

- Phrases can combine into bigger phrases **recursively**

the cuddly cat by the door

NP → NP PP

Context-Free Grammars

- Terminals
 - We'll take these to be words (for now)
- Non-Terminals
 - The constituents in a language (e.g., noun phrase)
- Rules
 - Consist of a single non-terminal on the left and any number of terminals and non-terminals on the right

An Example Grammar

Grammar Rules	Examples
$S \rightarrow NP VP$	I + want a morning flight
$NP \rightarrow$ <i>Pronoun</i> <i>Proper-Noun</i> <i>Det Nominal</i>	I Los Angeles a + flight
$Nominal \rightarrow$ <i>Nominal Noun</i> <i>Noun</i>	morning + flight flights
$VP \rightarrow$ <i>Verb</i> <i>Verb NP</i> <i>Verb NP PP</i> <i>Verb PP</i>	do want + a flight leave + Boston + in the morning leaving + on Thursday
$PP \rightarrow$ <i>Preposition NP</i>	from + Los Angeles

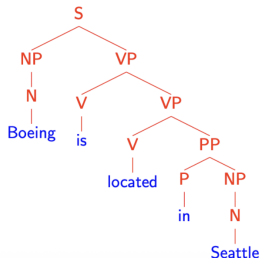
Syntactic parsing

- Syntactic parsing is the task of recognizing a sentence and assigning a structure to it.

Input:

Beoing is located in Seattle.

Output:

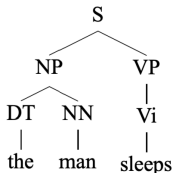


(Left-most) Derivations

- Given a CFG G , a left-most derivation is a sequence of strings $s_1, s_2, \dots, s_n$, where
 - $s_1 = S$
 - $s_n \in \Sigma^*$: all possible strings made up of words from Σ
 - Each s_i for $i = 2, \dots, n$ is derived from s_{i-1} by picking the left-most non-terminal X in s_{i-1} and replacing it by some β where $X \rightarrow \beta \in R$
- s_n : yield of the derivation

(Left-most) Derivations

- $s_1 = S$
- $s_2 = NP VP$
- $s_3 = DT NN VP$
- $s_4 = the NN VP$
- $s_5 = the man VP$
- $s_6 = the man Vi$
- $s_7 = the man sleeps$



$R =$

S	→	NP	VP
VP	→	Vi	
VP	→	Vt	NP
VP	→	VP	PP
NP	→	DT	NN
NP	→	NP	PP
PP	→	IN	NP

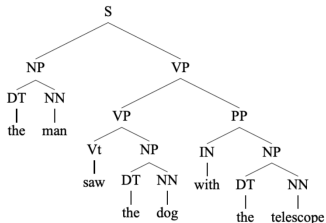
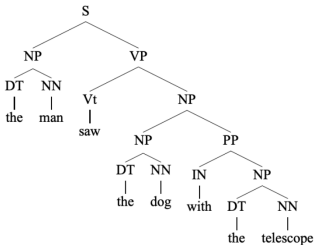
Vi	→	sleeps
Vt	→	saw
NN	→	man
NN	→	woman
NN	→	telescope
NN	→	dog
DT	→	the
IN	→	with
IN	→	in

A derivation can be represented as a parse tree!

- A string $s \in \Sigma^*$ is in the language defined by the CFG if there is at least one derivation whose yield is s
- The set of possible derivations may be finite or infinite

Ambiguity

- Some strings may have more than one derivations (i.e. more than one parse trees!).



The rise of annotated data

Starting off, building a treebank seems a lot slower and less useful than writing a grammar (by hand)

But a treebank gives us many things

- Reusability of the labor
 - Many parsers, part-of-speech taggers, etc. can be built on it
 - Valuable resource for linguistics
- Broad coverage, not just a few intuitions
- Frequencies and distributional information
- A way to evaluate NLP systems

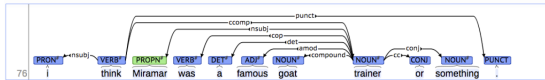
Treebanks

- Standard setup (WSJ portion of Penn Treebank):
 - 40,000 sentences for training
 - 1,700 for development
 - 2,400 for testing
- Why building a treebank instead of a grammar?
 - Broad coverage
 - Frequencies and distributional information
 - A way to evaluate systems

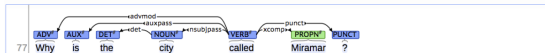
The rise of annotated data & Universal Dependencies treebanks

Brown corpus (1967; PoS tagged 1979); Lancaster-IBM Treebank (starting late 1980s);
Marcus et al. 1993, The Penn Treebank, *Computational Linguistics*;
Universal Dependencies: <http://universaldependencies.org/>

[context] [conllu]



[context] [conllu]

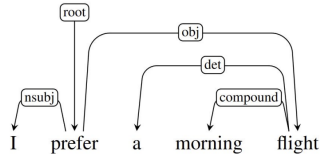


[context] [conllu]



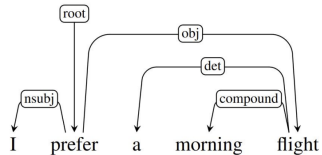
So what is dependency grammar?

- Directed binary grammatical relations between the words
- This direct encoding of the relationship between the predicates and their arguments (e.g., prefer takes I and flight as its arguments) is one of the reasons dependency grammar is more popular than constituency grammar in NLP!



So what is dependency grammar?

- Arcs go from heads to dependents
- Exactly 1 incoming edge for all tokens! (but can have many outgoing ones)
- **Root** is the head of the entire structure
- Especially useful for languages with **free word order** (constituency grammar is less suited to those)



Dependency relations

- **advmod**: adverb modifier
- **amod**: adjective modifier
- **aux**: auxiliary
- **case**: case marker
(think of this as object of preposition)
- **det**: determiner
- **iobj**: indirect object
- **nmod**: noun modifier
- **nmod:poss**: possessive modifier
- **nsubj**: subject
- **nummod**: number modifier
- **obj**: direct object
- **obl**: oblique case ("prepositionally marked nominals functioning adverbially")
- **root**: root

He walked happily

a big cat

two books

Nathan sent me an email

degree in biology

- My brother has a degree in biology.
- My brother has a degree in biology.
- My brother has a degree in biology.
- He walked happily.

- There is a big cat.
- I will study for the exam.
- I will study for the exam.
- I will study for the exam.
- I have two books.

- Nathan sent me an email on Monday.
- Nathan sent me an email on Monday.
- Nathan sent me an email on Monday.

Nathan sent me an email on Monday

My brother has

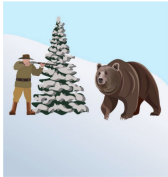
I will study

for the exam

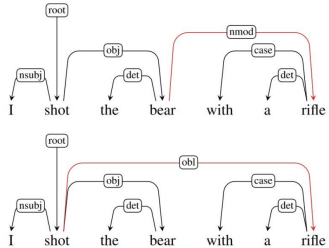
for the exam

Nathan sent me

Structural ambiguity (again!)



Images from: <https://www.cs.utexas.edu/~dnp/rego/subsection-178.html>
<https://www.istockphoto.com/vector/hunter-shoots-a-bear-am930143498-255034331>



Dependency Parsing

root?

She gave me the book

Dependency Parsing

Relation to *She*?

root

She

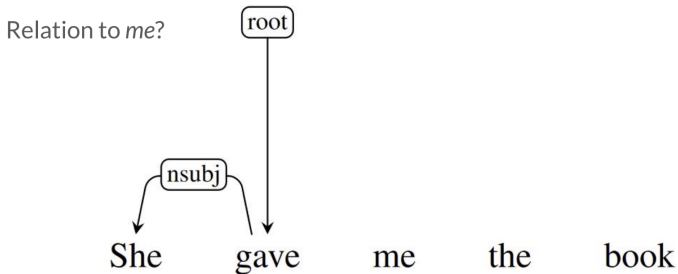
gave

me

the

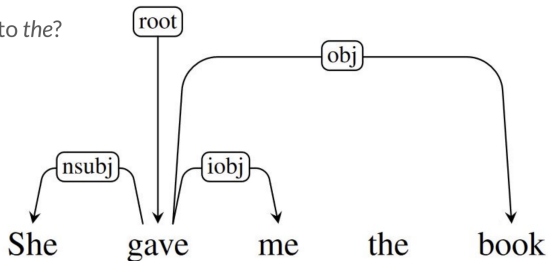
book

Let's try one!

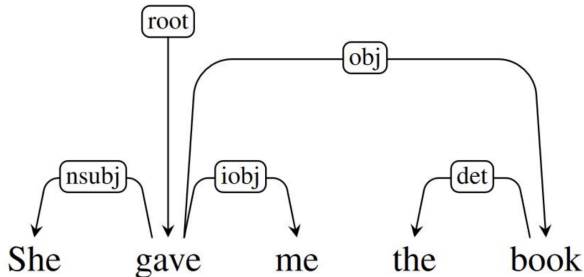


Let's try one!

Relation to *the*?



Let's try one!



3. Methods of Dependency Parsing

1. Dynamic programming

Eisner (1996) gives a clever algorithm with complexity $O(n^3)$, by producing parse items with heads at the ends rather than in the middle

2. Graph algorithms

You create a Minimum Spanning Tree for a sentence

McDonald et al.'s (2005) $O(n^2)$ MSTParser scores dependencies independently using an ML classifier (he uses MIRA, for online learning, but it can be something else)

Neural graph-based parser: Dozat and Manning (2017) et seq. – very successful!

3. Constraint Satisfaction

Edges are eliminated that don't satisfy hard constraints. Karlsson (1990), etc.

4. "Transition-based parsing" or "deterministic dependency parsing"

Greedy choice of attachments guided by good machine learning classifiers

E.g., MaltParser (Nivre et al. 2008). Has proven highly effective. And fast.

Transition-based Parsing

- Process words from left to right, deciding if the two words should be attached
- Build a dependency parse using a stack and buffer
- **Input buffer:** words of the sentence
- **Stack:** to manipulate the words
- **Dependency relations:** list of relations that culminate in the dependency parse

Transition-based Parsing

Arc-standard transition-based parser

(there are other transition schemes ...)

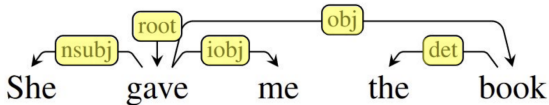
Analysis of “I ate fish”



Start: $\sigma = [\text{ROOT}]$, $\beta = w_1, \dots, w_n$, $A = \emptyset$
1. Shift $\sigma, w_i | \beta, A \rightarrow \sigma | w_i, \beta, A$
2. Left-Arc, $\sigma | w_i | w_j, \beta, A \rightarrow \sigma | w_j, \beta, AU\{r(w_i, w_j)\}$
3. Right-Arc, $\sigma | w_i | w_j, \beta, A \rightarrow \sigma | w_i, \beta, AU\{r(w_i, w_j)\}$
Finish: $\sigma = [w]$, $\beta = \emptyset$

Transition-based Parsing

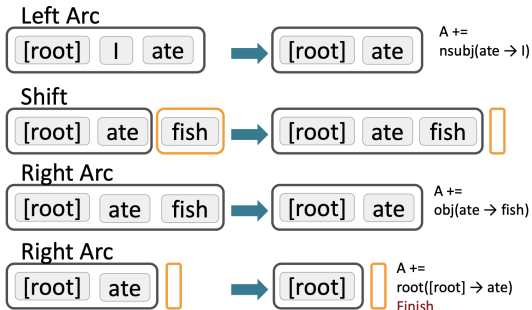
Step	Stack	Input Buffer	Action	Relation Added
0	[root]	[She, gave, me, the, book]	S	
1	[root, She]	[gave, me, the, book]	S	
2	[root, She, gave]	[me, the, book]	LA	(She $\leftarrow$ gave)
3	[root, gave]	[me, the, book]	S	
4	[root, gave, me]	[the, book]	RA	(gave $\rightarrow$ me)
5	[root, gave]	[the, book]	S	
6	[root, gave, the]	[book]	S	
7	[root, gave, the, book]	[]	LA	(the $\leftarrow$ book)
8	[root, gave, book]	[]	RA	(gave $\rightarrow$ book)
9	[root, gave]	[]	RA	(root $\rightarrow$ gave)
10	[root]	[]	Done	



Transition-based Parsing

Arc-standard transition-based parser

Analysis of “I ate fish”



Nota bene:

In this example I've at each step made the "correct" next transition. But a parser has to work this out – by exploring or inferring!

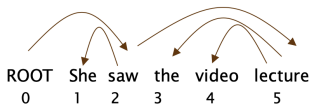
A = { nsubj(ate → I),
obj(ate → fish)
root([root] → ate) }

Transition-based Parsing

MaltParser [Nivre and Hall 2005]

- We have left to explain how we choose the next action 🤖
 - Answer: **Stand back, I know machine learning!**
- Each action is predicted by a discriminative classifier (e.g., softmax classifier) over each legal move
 - Max of 3 untyped choices (max of $|R| \times 2 + 1$ when typed)
 - Features: top of stack word, POS; first in buffer word, POS; etc.
- There is NO search (in the simplest form)
 - But you can profitably do a beam search if you wish (slower but better):
 - You keep k good parse prefixes at each time step
- The model's accuracy is *a bit* below the state of the art in dependency parsing, but
- It provides **very fast linear time parsing**, with high accuracy – great for parsing the web

Evaluation of Dependency Parsing: (labeled) dependency accuracy



$$\text{Acc} = \frac{\# \text{ correct deps}}{\# \text{ of deps}}$$

$$\text{UAS} = 4 / 5 = 80\%$$

$$\text{LAS} = 2 / 5 = 40\%$$

Gold

1	2	She	nsubj
2	0	saw	root
3	5	the	det
4	5	video	nn
5	2	lecture	obj

Parsed

1	2	She	nsubj
2	0	saw	root
3	4	the	det
4	5	video	nsubj
5	2	lecture	ccomp